

Sublime Symbols: Surfacing the Visual Vocabulary of Alt-right Corecore

Carl Illustrisimo*

University of California, Berkeley
School of Information

Abstract

An interactive visualization of the data is available at: https://cillustrisimo.github.io/sublime_symbols/.

1 Motivation

Intro

It is no secret that the internet and its algorithmically curated spaces have served as a powerful conduit for the spread of political ideology. Countless studies have emerged showcasing how alt-right content seeps across different online spaces, spreading far and wide, veiled in the guise of irony or esotericism. The spread of alt-right subculture is not innocuous, and has been increasingly linked to political violence in the real world being carried out by members of these digital spaces (Jipson and Becker, 2025; Conway et al., 2019). Parsing the convoluted landscape of alt-right content is therefore a critical matter and crucial step to understanding how such content could be combatted or reversed. To this end, I analyze the reactionary seizure of a popular art form, the corecore edit.

I define a corecore edit as an assemblage of different forms of media (photo, video, audio, text), structured in a non-logical format found initially on TikTok and now other platforms. It is essentially a video collage, replete with media pulled from varying sources and ingroup memes. Vujosevic and Chen trace corecore's affective force to its qualities as a sublime aesthetic experience (Vujošević, 2024; Chen, 2023). For Chen, corecore offers cathartic, "meaning-making" respite from the algorithmic doomscroll; Vujosevic extends this by linking the medium to romantic sensibilities—a belief in a "truer" reality beyond words. Both see corecore as encapsulating the doomscroll itself, repeating

algorithmic logic to assemble hyperaestheticized, fragmented content that communicates what language alone cannot.

Yet, while corecore is framed as a repetition of algorithm logic—fascist corecore edits abound, aestheticizing war, antiquity, and dictators against trending songs. We argue these moves are intentional, a tension evident in Vujosevic's own footnote acknowledging how incels have appropriated corecore for their own ends.

Corecore edits do not just aestheticize a reflection of an algorithmically curated feed, but rather, condense and shift that reflection, changing the character of the sublime felt through a human curation of the feed. Corecore edits are assembled. Repetition is not unique to corecore's relationship to the algorithm, but the *raison d'être* of TikTok. In practice, corecore creators reuse or create popular audios, tracing the algorithm to carefully select each element of the edit, while embedding in their edits their own recurrent symbols and themes. They do not blindly follow algorithmic logics then, but choose what to emphasize about the feed and what message to impart while maintaining a lulling familiarity through just enough closeness to the algorithm.

To illustrate this, we take a computational approach focused on identifying what Bharath Ganesh calls "white thymos," symbols that beget white supremacist affects, in popular corecore edits. **We operationalize this with the following questions:**

1. Can we surface symbols of white thymos in corecore and,
2. Can we use those symbols to distinguish between normative and alt-right instantiations of the genre?

Put shortly, we have found success in both of these questions, as we will show throughout this

*Note: While this is ACL format (which I keep for convenience), I am currently targeting either CHR, JCA, JCL, or ICWSM. I consider New Media + Society, as well.

report.

Relation to Existing Work

While a plethora of studies have been conducted on corecore from literary perspectives (Chen, 2023; Vujošević, 2024; Johanssen and Kay, 2024; Colquitt and Cobb, 2023), and computational studies of TikTok have been done with respect to social scientific and cultural questions (Klug et al., 2021; McCashin and Murphy, 2022; Zeng and Abidin, 2021; Cheng and Li, 2023), I am not aware of any computational studies of corecore to this date, nor any which attempt to blend literary and computational methods into one coherent analysis.

Likewise, I see my work fitting in with the plethora of studies which take place today studying the digital alt-right and their cultural artifacts. With respect to this tradition, I view my work fitting within the realm of researchers such as Nagle, Ganesh, and Ribeiro (Nagle, 2017; Ganesh, 2020; Ribeiro et al., 2019). However, the works that study the digital alt-right and their cultural artifacts—both from cultural theoretic and computational perspectives—have primarily focused on memes and discourse as broad phenomena. Additionally, they have focused on platforms such as Youtube (Ribeiro et al., 2019; Lewis, 2018), Twitter (Talat and Hovy, 2016), Reddit (Massanari and Chess, 2018), 4chan (Peeters et al., 2021; Yoder et al., 2024), and mixtures of all these platforms along with others like Instagram (Mami’e et al., 2021; Zannettou et al., 2018; Askanus, 2021; Askanus and Keller, 2021; Way, 2021; Özkula et al., 2024).

My work then seeks to carve out a unique space for itself amongst this literature. It is unique in taking a close reading of the corecore format through a combination of computational and literary analysis, and unique in studies of the alt-right by being an early study on the content of Tiktok and the Tiktok platform itself. Likewise, it holds potential to define new theoretical ground by building on the argument of Bharath Ganesh and further fleshing out a theory of *curated repetition* as the dominant mode of content creation online today.

2 Methods

Data Collection

I first scraped around 1492 Tiktok videos, and 20 comments from each video. 910 of those videos were scraped from alt-right associated tags on Tik-

tok, namely: ‘#hyperborea’, ‘#agartha’, ‘#vril’, and ‘#another X classic.’ Mainstream or baseline were scraped via the tags ‘#nichetok’, ‘#corecore’, and ‘#hopecore’. Initial analysis was performed on videos from the alt-right tags, which after filtering for english comments and selecting frames from each video, left us with 4710 images and 10909 comments for our analysis. To briefly explain the alt-right tags in order: hyperborea denotes a conspiracy theory of a hidden land beyond the ice of a flat-earth, agartha denotes an atlantis-esque land associated with the “aryan” people, vril refers to an old white supremacist fiction book, and another X classic denotes a common phrase by white-supremacists where X is replaced with terms like aryan or european.

Methodology in Depth

For ease, I encapsulate my computational methodology in figure 1, which describes each step taken after data collection and english comment filtering. We begin with the video data extraction step.

Video Data Extraction

The video data extraction step performs the following: get frames which best represent each video, and create dense image captions for those frames. Frames are extracted by taking a frame per second with OpenCV2, reducing the image size to 128x128, and then performing minibatch k-means clustering on a PCA of the image pixel vectors. Captioning is done with Microsoft’s Florence-2 base mode (Xiao et al., 2024), using the preset prompt for dense captioning.

Audio/Label Data Extraction

This component of the pipeline characterizes the musical content present in corecore edits to support analysis of aesthetic and thematic patterns. The implementation uses CLAP (Contrastive Language-Audio Pretraining), specifically the laion/larger_clap_music_and_speech model, to generate semantic music descriptions via similarity matching (Wu et al., 2023).

The pipeline proceeds as follows: First, audio is extracted from each video using FFmpeg, re-sampled to 48kHz mono WAV format. Descriptive terms are then sourced from Google’s MusicCaps dataset and organized into five semantic categories: genre, mood, instruments, tempo, and vocals (Agostinelli et al., 2023). These terms are pre-embedded using CLAP’s text encoder. For

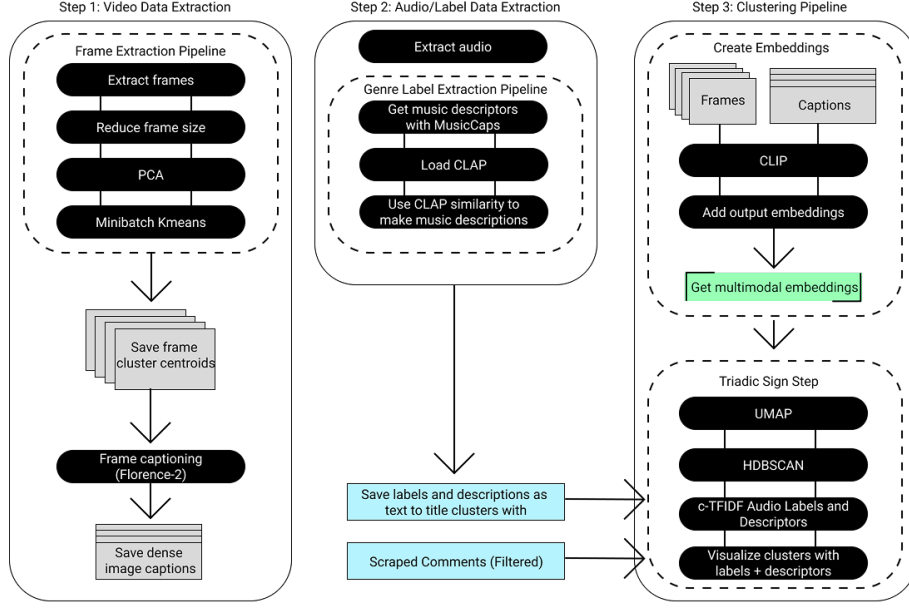


Figure 1: Overview of the pipeline

each audio file, the pipeline computes audio embeddings and matches them against the pre-computed text embeddings via cosine similarity, selecting the highest-scoring term per category. The results are assembled into natural language captions (e.g., “Energetic electronic featuring synth with fast tempo and male voice”).

To identify broader musical patterns across the corpus, the generated captions are represented in our output images as log-odds terms.

Clustering Pipeline

At a high-level, the methodology of this portion is inspired by the Peircean triadic model of semiotics, and creates a novel topic modeling pipeline from this inspiration. Peircean semiotics attempts to understand signs by breaking them into sign (the thing that stands for something else), object (what the sign represents), and interpretant (the meaning or effect produced by the sign). Thus, the visual outputs of this model contain the sign (cluster label), the object as text (currently from the captioning model, though this act has some theoretical haziness from a Peircean perspective), and interpretant (log-odds words derived from comments keyed to the posts).

To achieve the above, we first create our embeddings via a CLIP model. An embedding is generated for a given frame and the a caption keyed to that frame, after which, the two are added together via simple element-wise vector addition to improve their clustering performance (Cai et al.,

2024). These multimodal embeddings are then fed into UMAP to be dimensionally reduced, and then HDBSCAN to be clustered. Then, images which are taken to be “representative” of the sign are derived by selecting items in the cluster with the highest stability scores. From the set of potential representatives taken in the previous step, we select representatives using greedy submodular optimization, which optimizes selection of items in the face of diminishing returns, or in our case, redundant information (Nemhauser et al., 1978). We operationalize the task as follows:

Let $\mathcal{V} = \{v_1, \dots, v_n\}$ denote candidate frames with high HDBSCAN stability scores, each represented by its CLIP embedding. We select k representatives $\mathcal{S} \subseteq \mathcal{V}$ that maximize diversity via a submodular coverage function:

$$F(\mathcal{S}) = \sum_{v \in \mathcal{V}} \min_{s \in \mathcal{S}} d(v, s) \quad (1)$$

where d denotes cosine distance. We employ a greedy algorithm that iteratively selects the frame with maximum marginal gain:

$$v_i = \operatorname{argmax}_{v \in \mathcal{V} - \mathcal{S}_{i-1}} \left(\min_{s \in \mathcal{S}_{i-1}} d(v, s) \right) \quad (2)$$

The algorithm initializes each $\mathcal{S}$ with the cluster centroid (taken by averaging the embeddings), then iteratively adds frames until $|\mathcal{S}| = k$. This greedy approach provides a $(1 - 1/e)$ -approximation guarantee while ensuring selected representatives are maximally diverse (Krause and Golovin, 2014).

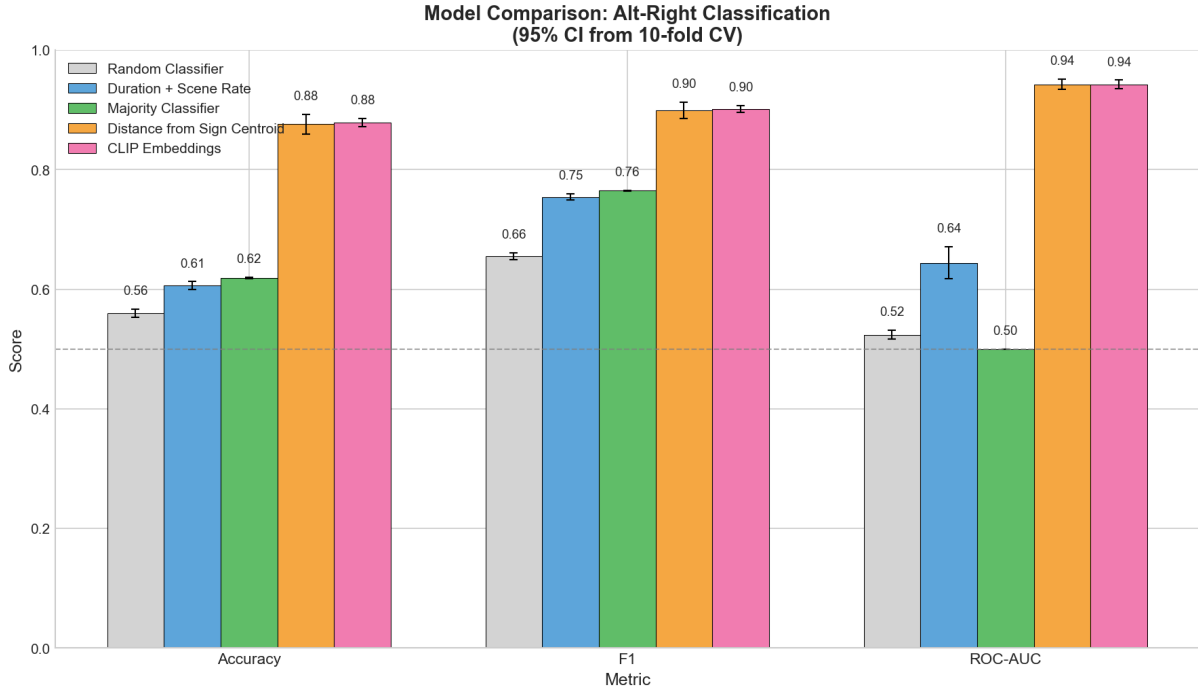


Figure 2: Comparison of models for classification

After getting representative frames, a composite image is created from these frames with PIL. We then derive emblematic caption text through TFIDF for the clusters, and the interpretant text by calculating log-odds (as mentioned earlier). The cluster composites, caption text, and comment text are then all displayed in a 3x3 grid via matplotlib.

3 Evaluation

To validate that our sign clusters capture meaningful discriminative structure, we evaluate their utility as features for classifying alt-right versus mainstream TikTok content. This evaluation serves two purposes: (1) demonstrating that the learned clusters encode visual patterns predictive of alt-right content, and (2) comparing the representational efficiency of cluster-based features against raw embeddings.

Classification Task

We frame alt-right content detection as a binary classification problem, where each video is labeled based on its source hashtag (alt-right: #hyperborea, #agartha, #vril, #another classic; mainstream: #corecore, #hopecore). For each video, we compute the average CLIP embedding across sampled frames (1 frame per second), then measure cosine similarity from this embedding to each of the $k = 189$ cluster centroids,

yielding a 189-dimensional representation where each dimension encodes similarity to a specific visual sign.

Models Compared

We compare five approaches using stratified 10-fold cross-validation:

- **Random Classifier:** Baseline predicting classes randomly, weighted by class distribution
- **Majority Classifier:** Baseline always predicting the majority class (alt-right)
- **Duration + Scene Rate:** Logistic regression on video metadata (duration in seconds, scene transitions per second)
- **Distance from Sign Centroids:** Logistic regression on cluster-based similarity features (189 dimensions)
- **CLIP Embeddings:** Logistic regression on raw CLIP embeddings as an upper bound (512 dimensions)

All logistic regression models use standardized features and L2 regularization.

Model	Acc.	F1	AUC
Random	.560 ± .007	.656 ± .006	.524 ± .007
Majority	.619 ± .001	.765 ± .001	.500 ± .000
Duration + Scene	.606 ± .007	.754 ± .005	.644 ± .026
Sign Centroid	.876 ± .016	.900 ± .014	.943 ± .009
CLIP Embed.	.878 ± .007	.902 ± .006	.943 ± .007

Table 1: Classification performance (10-fold CV, 95% CI)

Results

Our cluster-based similarity features achieve classification performance statistically equivalent to raw CLIP embeddings (accuracy: 0.876 vs 0.878, paired t -test $p > 0.05$), while reducing dimensionality by 63% (189 vs 512 features). Both embedding-based approaches substantially outperform metadata baselines, with ROC-AUC scores of 0.943 indicating strong discriminative power.

Notably, video-level metadata (duration and scene rate) performs at chance level, suggesting that alt-right and mainstream corecore videos share similar temporal structure and pacing. Thus, the distinction lies in visual content, not editing style. This aligns with our theoretical framework. Alt-right creators deliberately maintain “lulling familiarity through just enough closeness to the algorithm,” adhering to corecore’s genre conventions while embedding distinct visual signs. A *curated repetition*. The discriminative signal thus lies not in editing style, but in the specific iconographic content—the recurrent symbols encoding white thymos that our cluster-based approach successfully captures.

Evaluation Interpretation

These results support several key claims about our sign clustering methodology:

1. **Discriminative Validity.** The near-equivalent performance between cluster distances and raw CLIP embeddings demonstrates that our 189 sign clusters successfully capture the visual structure that distinguishes alt-right content. The clustering process preserves discriminatively relevant information while discarding redundant variance.
2. **Dimensionality Reduction with Interpretability.** We achieve 99.8% of the CLIP baseline’s accuracy using 63% fewer features. Crucially, unlike the opaque 512-dimensional

CLIP space, each of our 189 dimensions corresponds to a specific, interpretable visual sign cluster. This enables qualitative explanation of classification decisions (e.g., “this video was classified as alt-right due to high similarity to clusters containing Sonnenrad symbolism and Hyperborean landscapes”).

3. **Domain-Specific Visual Vocabulary.** The sign composite centroids function as a vocabulary of extremist visual rhetoric. Rather than relying on general-purpose image features, we are able to encode the specific iconographic patterns characteristic of alt-right TikTok content. This domain adaptation likely explains why cluster features match raw CLIP performance despite the dimensionality reduction.

Evaluation Limitations

The classification task relies on hashtag-based labels as a proxy for alt-right content, which introduces noise—not all videos under alt-right hashtags necessarily contain extremist messaging, and some mainstream videos may employ similar aesthetics ironically or critically. Additionally, our dataset exhibits class imbalance (62% alt-right), reflected in the majority classifier’s 0.619 accuracy baseline. Future work should incorporate human annotation to validate cluster semantics and classification accuracy on independently labeled data.

4 Analysis

We have shown, in the evaluation section, that the symbols we have can be used to distinguish between alt-right and Mainstream corecore edits. What makes these symbols however, alt-right? While a great many of intriguing symbols have been unearthed by our pipeline (a sample is shown in Figure 3), we hone in on three signs which exemplify the range in our results and reify our argument of the curated repetition of alt-right corecore: sign 156, sign 167, and sign 10. Our results thus far are also made easy to explore via an interactive visualization, which allows you to explore the sign clusters visually and sonically, including signs now shown in Figure 3.¹

Sign 156: Sensuous Conquest

Sign 156’s most representative audio is a remix of Demi Lovato’s “Cool for the Summer,” specifically

¹Interactive visualization available at https://cillustrisimo.github.io/sublime_symbols/

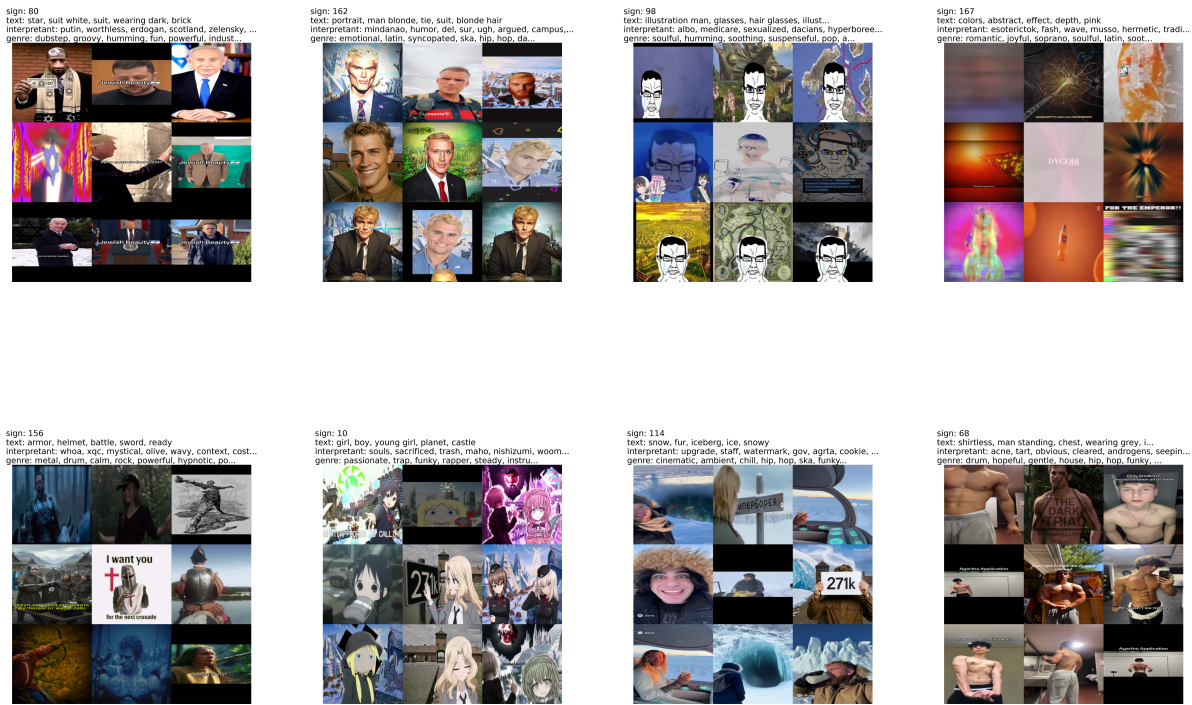


Figure 3: Sample of symbols

set to the lyrics "take me down into your paradise, don't be scared cause I'm your body type...." It predominately features images of Western warriors like crusaders or vikings, set in the backdrop of lush plains or rich forestry.

Historically speaking, there is no rhyme or reason as to the warriors included, no logic to who is featured across these corecore edits in this way. They contain cultures who have historically been at odds with each other or do not share a temporal moment, like Roman legionnaires, vikings, conquistadors, and even mythic figures like Brad Pitt's rendition of Achilles in *Troy*. Such a conflation of warriors across time, history, and mythos appear intended to evoke an affect of vastness—White culture is one of beautiful warmaking and conquest, an unbroken legacy throughout time and empires. Noel Ignatiev has highlighted this illogical sublation of various cultures into a singular idea of "white" as a function of its marker, a marker not reflective of culture, but rather of a social position in the contemporary world marked with certain privileges (Ignatiev, 1997). Whiteness constructs a legacy and mythos to itself, in spite of culture.

The images then, appear intended to be a reminder of this constructed legacy, punctuated by its setting to Demi Lovato's song. The song is facially about having sex, but set on these images, takes on

a whole new meaning. A common alt-right meme is "which way western man" (Frey, 2025), a reference to the book by white supremacist William Gayley Simpson, and often used to denote the crossroads White supremacists believe the West to be at—to continue falling to the weak-willed and contemptuous virtues of modernity, or to take back up their rightful legacy of domination. Against these images then, this song is meant to be not about giving in to the temptation of sex, but the temptations of conquest, war, and colonialism. These are states that are seen as a "paradise" by the alt-right, states that should not be feared by modern the western man because they are indeed natural to him, they are his "body type." The image at the center of this cluster, a crusader pointing at the viewer in the style of Uncle Sam stating "I want you for the next crusade," reifies this intended affect.

The outliers of this sign serve to further reify the illogic and sensuousness of these themes. Viewing the images inside the cluster, two which stand out are images of women in prairies, and of Mongolian horseback archers.⁴ The women appear represent to represent the pastoral ideal of "White culture," the thing that conquest is meant to protect and fight on behalf of, another side of the sensuous nature of this cluster emblemized by Demi Lovato's song. It also speaks directly to critiques like that of Ig-

natiev's, a direct argument against the notion that Whiteness erases European culture by asserting the images shown *are* White culture. The Mongolian horseback archers however, again punctuate the illogic and arbitrariness of this argument. While currently an obscure meme, this invocation of Mongolians is likely a reference to the growing alt-right meme "Fingolia," which is best exemplified by tik-tokers like "The Agarthan Unc," and posits that the Finnish and other Northern European's are the true descendants of the Mongolians. How else could they have conquered the world, if they were not white?

Sign 10: Anime

For more traditional reactionary aesthetics, which are focused on strength and perceived racial legacies like the ones in the previous cluster, an anime-centric sign cluster might seem surprising. The characters are often Japanese, and are often made to be cute. However, for the contemporary terminally-online alt-right, reactionary elements have long been embedded within the anime fandom, with such connections drawing far back to the early internet from the "netto-uyoku" (Net Right-Wing)(Fujioka, 2019) to today's groypers (Nazaryan, 2025). The presence of anime then should not come as a surprise, but serves to further highlight many key elements of alt-right imagery, namely, of irony and of purposeful obscurity.

Everything about this cluster is about irony, dogwhistles, and plausible deniability.⁵ To wit, while this cluster showcases how anime is recurrent through alt-right corecore edits, it also showcases how intentional the selection of animes is. The Blonde character is Kay, from the anime Kay, anime series *Girls und Panzer* (an anime about an alternate Japan where high school students compete in WW2 style "Panzerfahren" tank battles as sport), standing in front of Auschwitz. She is seen standing in front of a sign that states "271k," a number which is used by white supremacists to promote holocaust denial (Arolsen Archives, 2024). The black haired Character is Chito from *Girl's Last Tour*, a post apocalyptic anime that borrows heavily from the Nazi Aesthetics of WW2, where the character Chito and her friend travels on a German Kettengrad (the motorcycle used by the Wehrmacht) (*Girls' Last Tour* Wiki contributors, 2024). The other characters standing in front of the icy landscape are also from *Girls und Panzer*.

From the specifically romanticized invocations

of WW2 through these anime characters, we find that this sign reifies assertions like that of Fujioka's about the embeddedness of anime and online subculture generally into the alt-right (Fujioka, 2019). It further reifies the notions of irony and plausible deniability put forth by scholars like Nagle (Nagle, 2017). However, from this cluster, we also see further hints as to how alt-right dogwhistles function; namely, their multifaceted nature. The character Kay, for example, is standing in front of Auschwitz with a number signifying holocaust denial. The character Chito is seen drinking a flask of "raw milk"², and the other characters appear to be standing in front of "Hyperborea."

Each sign in this cluster then carries continuous layers of irony and obscurity that further dilute the message, but also make it more semantically rich for those who the message is intended for. To wit, the signs with the *Girls und Panzer* characters standing in front of Hyperborea also contain a green sun-like symbol in the background, with text saying "Whatsappborea is calling you." This sun is made to appear like a sonnerad, or Nazi esoteric black sun, but its Whatsapp styling is initially confusing. Further literature review reveals that whatsapp has been tied to alt-right and extremist movements for its affordance to spread extremist rhetoric under the radar, yet has been noted to be currently underdocumented as a symbol itself (Chagas, 2024). Contextualizing the sign cluster then with this previous research lends to an interpretation that the Whatsapp branding appears to be an extension of open arms, a cute face to go with an invitation to join in on the alt-right discourse (Chagas, 2024).

Sign 167: Fash Wave

Sign 167⁶, upon first brush, appears to be largely noise. The sign cluster is a mess of blurry, hazy, and dreamlike images—each suffused with a kind of static glow reminiscent of a VHS video. It is hard to make sense of this cluster until we begin looking at the interpretant terms, or log-odds comments terms, most associated with this cluster. Terms like "fash wave" and "esoteric-tok" show at the top of the list, the representative audio paired with the cluster a hyperpop-esque remix, and the image captions describing the entire cluster as a "pink abstract art piece." The signs coupled in this cluster then position themselves as a microcosm of alt-right ap-

²<https://theconversation.com/milk-a-symbol-of-neo-nazi-hate-83292>

523 appropriation of genre templates and aesthetics for
524 their message, but in this case, of the combina-
525 tion of core-core with a fascistic cooptation of the
526 classic internet art movement "Vaporwave."

527 Vaporwave is an internet-born art movement that
528 saw prominence during the 2010s, peaking in pop-
529 ularity in the earlier part of the decade and experi-
530 encing a minor resurgence closer to the end. It is
531 a retro styled aesthetic, cultivated around slowed
532 down samples of funk and disco songs that are
533 edited in specific way so as to evoke an ethereal
534 feeling of nostalgia, often interpreted as a critique
535 of the shallowness of consumer culture by evoking
536 the empty consumer culture of the 80s (Glitsos,
537 2018). Its most famous album is often stated to be
538 Macintosh Plus' *Floral Shoppe*, which is credited
539 with defining the genre, and features a Roman bust
540 against a hazy pink checkboard background.³

541 A look at the album covers of Vaporwave's old-
542 est hits makes clear then what the comment terms
543 "fash wave" are intending to evoke. The famous
544 album cover for *Floral Shoppe* is reinterpreted in
545 this cluster with a multi-layered, racist depiction
546 of George Floyd. He is seen as a disembodied
547 head floating against a hazy pink background. Be-
548 low him is checkerboard of vectorized lines, and
549 on his head is a pharaoh's hat. Like the previ-
550 ous cluster, this sign encodes multiple dogwhistles
551 into one image—with violent depictions of George
552 Floyd being a common motif of alt-right imagery
553 (as observable in our clusters), and the Pharaoh's
554 hat a reference to the racist meme phrase "we wuz
555 kangs" (Anti-Defamation League, 2019). This sign
556 cluster thus represents a fascistic interpretation of
557 Vaporwave, reusing its aesthetic to appeal again to
558 the terminally-online alt-right, but also to extend its
559 reach into the centers of cultural production on the
560 internet. Vaporwave is often seen as one of the few
561 artistic aesthetics that has emerged in the internet
562 era, and thus is emblematic of online, niche music
563 and art culture itself. By reusing the Vaporwave
564 aesthetic then, the "fash wave" cluster attempts to
565 position reactionary politics as a part of online cul-
566 ture itself.

567 5 Limitations

568 While the current findings show that our method
569 is a useful means of cataloging alt-right symbols,
570 specifically that inductively identified alt-right sym-

571 bols can aid with the task of alt-right content de-
572 tection, there are a few limitations. Firstly, our
573 method, as a general means of clustering imagery
574 from short-form content, struggles with smaller
575 symbols. Objects like a monster can that a charac-
576 ter is drinking, or of Sonnerad's in the background,
577 are ignored for larger structural trends in the im-
578 ages. These symbols are equally important and
579 present throughout all clusters, but not captured in
580 their own grouping. Future work would do well to
581 capture these smaller symbols, perhaps by patching
582 the image out and embedding specific patches, or
583 other techniques better attuned to smaller symbols
584 recurrent throughout our images.

585 Additionally, our current analysis is based on
586 approximately 900 videos scraped from alt-right-
587 associated hashtags ('#hyperborea', '#agartha',
588 '#vril', '#another X classic'). Findings repre-
589 sent patterns within this specific dataset, and may
590 change with larger samples. Future work would do
591 well to perform this pipeline on a larger set of data.

592 6 Conclusion

593 This study demonstrates that the visual vocabu-
594 lary of alt-right corecore can be systematically
595 identified and leveraged for content classification.
596 Through a Peircean-inspired clustering pipeline,
597 we surfaced 189 sign clusters encoding symbols
598 of white thymos—from the sensuous conquest fan-
599 tasies of Sign 156 to the ironic dogwhistles of the
600 anime cluster and the fascist appropriation of va-
601 porwave in "fash wave." These clusters achieve
602 87.6% classification accuracy, matching raw CLIP
603 embeddings while reducing dimensionality by 63%
604 and maintaining interpretability.

605 Crucially, our finding that visual content dis-
606 criminates where video metadata cannot confirms
607 that alt-right corecore operates through deliberate
608 iconographic choices rather than distinctive editing
609 styles, or mere repetitions of algorithmic logic. Alt-
610 right creators adhere to genre conventions while
611 embedding extremist symbols, exploiting the for-
612 mat's association with algorithmic catharsis to
613 naturalize white supremacist affects. This work
614 thus offers the potential to contribute to a novel
615 dataset for cataloging extremist visual rhetoric on
616 short-form video platforms, and a theoretical ar-
617 gument against technodeterministic accounts of
618 corecore—revealing it as a site of intentional po-
619 litical assembly where the repetition that defines
620 TikTok is weaponized for ideological ends.

³<https://vapor95.com/blogs/darknet/top-10-vaporwave-albums>

References

- Andrea Agostinelli, Timo I. Denk, Zalan Borsos, Jesse Engel, Mauro Verzetti, Antoine Caber, Aren Jansen, Adam Roberts, Marco Tagliasacchi, Matthew Sharifi, Neil Zeghidour, and Christian Frank. 2023. Musi-clm: Generating music from text. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2301.11325*.
- Anti-Defamation League. 2019. [We wuz kangas](#). Hate on Display database.
- Arolsen Archives. 2024. [Fact check: This document does not relativize the Holocaust!](#)
- Tina Askanius. 2021. [On frogs, monkeys, and execution memes: Exploring the humor-hate nexus at the intersection of neo-nazi and alt-right movements in sweden](#). *Television & New Media*, 22:147 – 165.
- Tina Askanius and N. Keller. 2021. [Murder fantasies in memes: fascist aesthetics of death threats and the banalization of white supremacist violence](#). *Information, Communication & Society*, 24:2522 – 2539.
- Yuanyuan Cai, Satoshi Kosugi, Kotaro Funakoshi, and Manabu Okumura. 2024. Enhancing image clustering with captions. In *Proceedings of the 38th Pacific Asia Conference on Language, Information and Computation*, pages 246–255.
- Viktor Chagas. 2024. [Far-right memespheres and platform affordances: the effects of environmental opacity on the spread of extremist memes on Twitter and WhatsApp](#). *Journal of Applied Communication Research*, 52(4):517–533.
- Min Chen. 2023. [Explained: What is corecore, the dadaesque ‘artistic movement’ now trending on tiktok?](#)
- Zicheng Cheng and Yanlin Li. 2023. [Like, comment, and share on tiktok: Exploring the effect of sentiment and second-person view on the user engagement with tiktok news videos](#). *Social Science Computer Review*, 42:201 – 223.
- Declan Colquitt and Hannah Cobb. 2023. [A postmortem of corecore](#).
- Maura Conway, Ryan Scrivens, and Logan Macnair. 2019. [Right-wing extremists’ persistent online presence: History and contemporary trends](#). Policy brief, International Centre for Counter-Terrorism, The Hague.
- Elliott Frey. 2025. [“which way, american man?”: The utility of memes for the trump administration](#). *Fair Observer*.
- Brett Fujioka. 2019. [Japan’s cynical romantics, precursors to the alt-right](#). *Tablet Magazine*. Accessed: 2024-12-19.
- Bharath Ganesh. 2020. [Weaponizing white thymos: Flows of rage in the online audiences of the alt-right](#). *Cultural Studies*, 34(6):892–924.
- Girls’ Last Tour Wiki contributors. 2024. [Kettenkrad](#).
- Laura Glitsos. 2018. Vaporwave, or music optimised for abandoned malls. *Popular Music*, 37(1):100–118.
- Noel Ignatiev. 1997. [The point is not to interpret whiteness but to abolish it](#). Talk given at the conference “The Making and Unmaking of Whiteness”.
- Art Jipson and Paul J. Becker. 2025. [Right-wing extremist violence is more frequent and more deadly than left-wing violence: What the data shows](#). *The Conversation*.
- Jacob Johanssen and J. Kay. 2024. [From femcels to ‘femcelcore’: Women’s involuntary celibacy and the rise of heteronihilism](#). *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 28:981 – 999.
- D. Klug, Yiluo Qin, Morgan C. Evans, and Geoff F. Kaufman. 2021. [Trick and please. a mixed-method study on user assumptions about the tiktok algorithm](#). *Proceedings of the 13th ACM Web Science Conference 2021*.
- Andreas Krause and Daniel Golovin. 2014. [Submodular function maximization](#). In Lucas Bordeaux, Youssef Hamadi, and Pushmeet Kohli, editors, *Tractability: Practical Approaches to Hard Problems*, pages 71–104. Cambridge University Press.
- Rebecca Lewis. 2018. [Alternative influence: broadcasting the reactionary right on youtube](#). In *unknown*.
- Robin Mami’e, Manoel Horta Ribeiro, and Robert West. 2021. [Are anti-feminist communities gateways to the far right? evidence from reddit and youtube](#). *Proceedings of the 13th ACM Web Science Conference 2021*.
- Adrienne L Massanari and S. Chess. 2018. [Attack of the 50-foot social justice warrior: the discursive construction of sjw memes as the monstrous feminine](#). *Feminist Media Studies*, 18:525 – 542.
- Darragh McCashin and Colette Murphy. 2022. [Using tiktok for public and youth mental health – a systematic review and content analysis](#). *Clinical Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, 28:279 – 306.
- Angela Nagle. 2017. [Kill all normies: Online culture wars from 4chan and Tumblr to Trump and the alt-right](#). John Hunt Publishing.
- Alexander Nazaryan. 2025. [Who are the ‘groyper’?](#) *The New York Times*. Also published in Herald/Review Media.
- George L. Nemhauser, Laurence A. Wolsey, and Marshall L. Fisher. 1978. [An analysis of approximations for maximizing submodular set functions—I](#). *Mathematical Programming*, 14(1):265–294.
- S. Özkula, Tom Divon, Hadas Schlussek, and Danka Ninković Slavnić. 2024. [Special issue on methods in visual politics and protest](#). *Journal of Digital Social Research*.

- S.C.J. Peeters, M. Tuters, Tom Willaert, and D. D. Zeeuw. 2021. [On the vernacular language games of an antagonistic online subculture](#). *Frontiers in Big Data*, 4.
- Manoel Horta Ribeiro, Raphael Ottoni, Robert West, Virgílio A. F. Almeida, and Wagner Meira Jr. 2019. [Auditing radicalization pathways on youtube](#). *Proceedings of the 2020 Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency*.
- Zeerak Talat and Dirk Hovy. 2016. [Hateful symbols or hateful people? predictive features for hate speech detection on twitter](#). In *North American Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics*.
- Vuk M. Vujošević. 2024. CORECORE: Hyperromanticism and the postpandemic internet aesthetic. *Folia Linguistica et Litteraria*, (48):145–164.
- Lyndon C. S. Way. 2021. [Trump, memes and the alt-right: Emotive and affective criticism and praise](#). *Russian Journal of Linguistics*.
- Yusong Wu, Ke Chen, Tianyu Zhang, Yuchen Hui, Taylor Berg-Kirkpatrick, and Shlomo Dubnov. 2023. Large-scale contrastive language-audio pretraining with feature fusion and keyword-to-caption augmentation. In *IEEE International Conference on Acoustics, Speech and Signal Processing (ICASSP)*.
- Bin Xiao, Haiping Wu, Weijian Xu, Xiyang Dai, Houdong Hu, Yumao Lu, Michael Zeng, Ce Liu, and Lu Yuan. 2024. [Florence-2: Advancing a unified representation for a variety of vision tasks](#). In *Proceedings of the IEEE/CVF Conference on Computer Vision and Pattern Recognition (CVPR)*, pages 4818–4829.
- Michael Miller Yoder, D. W. Brown, and K. Carley. 2024. [The “chanification” of white supremacist extremism](#). *Computational and Mathematical Organization Theory*, 31:222 – 235.
- Savvas Zannettou, T. Caulfield, Jeremy Blackburn, Emiliano De Cristofaro, Michael Sirivianos, G. Stringhini, and Guillermo Suarez-Tangil. 2018. [On the origins of memes by means of fringe web communities](#). *Proceedings of the Internet Measurement Conference 2018*.
- Jing Zeng and C. Abidin. 2021. [‘#okboomer, time to meet the zoomers’: studying the memefication of intergenerational politics on tiktok](#). *Information, Communication & Society*, 24:2459 – 2481.



Figure 4: Sign 156: Mentioned Images

Cluster Range Analysis (euclidean distance to centroid)

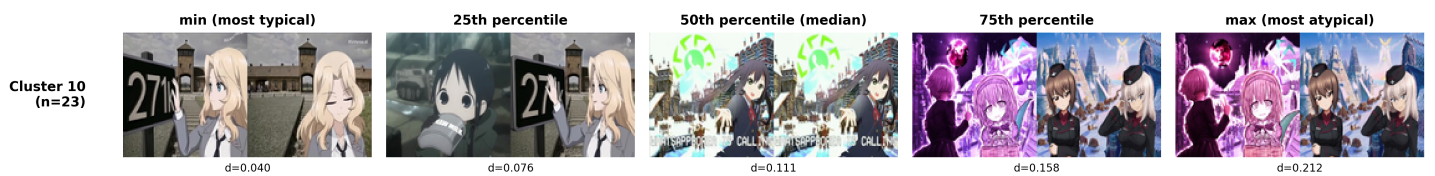


Figure 5: Sign 10: Range of Images

sign: 167

text: colors, abstract, effect, depth, pink

interpretant: esoterictok, fash, wave, musso, hermetic, tradition, clip...

genre: romantic, joyful, soprano, soulful, latin, soothing, groo...



Figure 6: Sign 167: Selected Images from Fash Wave